Index and official sources

Find the topic then verify deeper details

Current foundations

Variables 4 Types 5-6 Strings 7 Lists 8 Input 9 Operators 10 Conditions 11 Loops 12-13 Functions 14-15

Future foundations

Dictionaries 17 Exceptions 18 Files 19 Modules 20 Classes 21 Testing 22 Style 23 Glossary 24

More practice

Nested data 25 Comprehensions and sorting 26 Program planning 27

Official Python tutorial

docs.python.org/3/tutorial/

Official built-in types

docs.python.org/3/library/stdtypes.html

Search formula

Search Python plus your goal plus the type: Python sort list, Python convert string to int, Python dictionary get default.

Python Field Guide

A student reference for reading writing and debugging Python

Use it like a programmer

Find the idea you need, study the pattern, change one part, and run a small test.

Current learning comes first

Pages 3 through 16 cover the concepts used in class so far. Later pages prepare you for future projects.

You are allowed to look things up

The goal is not perfect memory. The goal is choosing the right tool and explaining what your code does.

How to use this guide

A four step lookup routine

1 Name the goal

Say what you want the program to do without using code words.

2 Find a pattern

Use the index or headings to locate a small example that matches your goal.

3 Adapt carefully

Change names and values, but keep punctuation, indentation, and the overall shape.

4 Predict and test

Predict the output, run the smallest useful test, and compare the result with your prediction.

When asking for help

Share what you expected, what happened, the smallest relevant code, and the complete error message.

Plan a program

Turn a large idea into testable steps

Inputs

What information enters the program? What type should each input have?

Outputs

What should the user see or receive? What should a function return?

Rules

Write the decisions and repeated actions as plain-language steps before writing Python.

Functions

Give each major job a name, inputs, and one expected output or effect.

Tests

Create one normal example, one boundary example, and one invalid example before implementation.

Comprehensions and sorting

Future shortcuts after loops make sense

List comprehension

squares = [number ** 2 for number in range(6)]

Filtered comprehension

passing = [score for score in scores if score >= 70]

Sorted copy

```
ordered = sorted(scores)
descending = sorted(scores, reverse=True)
```

Choose clarity

Use a normal loop when the shortcut becomes hard to explain. Shorter code is not always clearer code.

What we have learned

Current course map

Data

Variables, strings, numbers, Boolean values, None, lists, and input.

Decisions

Comparisons, if, elif, else, and Boolean logic.

Repetition

for loops, range, while loops, counters, and accumulators.

Organization

Functions, parameters, arguments, return values, and local variables.

Problem solving

Tracing, reading errors, testing small pieces, and using precise searches.

Variables and names

Give values useful labels

Assignment

```
player_name = "Mario"
lives = 3
is_ready = True
```

Read it right to left

Python evaluates the expression on the right, then stores that value under the name on the left.

Reassignment

```
coins = 5
coins = coins + 1
# coins is now 6
```

Good names

Use lowercase words joined by underscores: total_score, student_name, has_key.

Constants by convention

Names written in ALL_CAPS usually represent values the program does not intend to change.

Nested data

Future structures inside structures

List of dictionaries

```
students = [
    {"name": "Ava", "score": 88},
    {"name": "Noah", "score": 94},
]
```

Read a nested value

first_name = students[0]["name"]

Loop through records

```
for student in students:
    print(student["name"], student["score"])
```

Work one layer at a time

First identify the outer type, select one value, then apply the operation for the inner type.

Glossary

Words programmers use

Expression and statement

An expression produces a value. A statement performs an action such as assignment or return.

Function method and argument

A function is callable code. A method belongs to an object. An argument is a value passed into a call.

Mutable and immutable

Mutable objects can change in place. Immutable objects cannot. Lists are mutable; strings and tuples are immutable.

Iterable and iteration

An iterable can supply values one at a time. One pass through a loop body is an iteration.

Bug and exception

A bug is incorrect behavior. An exception is a runtime signal that normal execution cannot continue.

Types overview

A type tells Python what a value is and what it can do

Core types

int whole number float decimal number str text bool True or False NoneType no value

Collection types

list ordered and changeable tuple ordered and fixed dict key-value pairs set unique values

Inspect a type

```
score = 12
print(type(score))      # <class 'int'>
print(isinstance(score, int))  # True
```

Why types matter

The + operator adds numbers but joins strings. Methods also depend on type: lists have append, strings do not.

Type errors

A TypeError often means an operation received a kind of value it cannot use.

Numbers booleans and None

Three kinds of values that often control programs

Numbers

```
whole = 7          # int
decimal = 2.5      # float
result = 7 / 2      # 3.5
```

Useful operators

+ add - subtract * multiply / divide // floor divide % remainder ** power

Boolean values

True and False are bool values. Comparisons such as score >= 10 produce a Boolean result.

None

None means no value. It is not zero, False, or an empty string. Check it with value is None.

Function connection

A function that reaches its end without return automatically returns None.

Style and readable code

Make programs easier for people to understand

Indent consistently

Use four spaces for each block. Do not mix tabs and spaces.

Name clearly

Prefer calculate_average over calc or x. Boolean names often begin with is, has, or can.

Keep functions focused

Split a long task into smaller named functions with clear inputs and return values.

Comments explain why

Do not narrate obvious code. Explain a decision, rule, assumption, or surprising workaround.

Whitespace helps

Use blank lines between major parts and spaces around operators so code is easier to scan.

Testing

Future confidence checks

Arrange act assert

Arrange inputs, act by calling the code, then assert the expected result.

Simple checks

```
assert power(7, 5) == 12
assert double(0) == 0
assert double(-3) == -6
```

Test boundaries

Try empty input, zero, one item, negative values, missing values, and the smallest or largest allowed value.

One behavior per test

A focused test makes failures easier to understand and repair.

Strings

Work with text

Create and combine

```
first = "Ada"
last = 'Lovelace'
full = first + " " + last
```

Index and slice

```
word = "Python"
word[0]      # 'P'
word[-1]     # 'n'
word[1:4]    # 'yth'
```

Common methods

name.strip() name.lower() name.upper()
text.replace("old", "new") text.split(",")

Formatted strings

```
name = "Sam"
score = 92
message = f"{name} scored {score}"
```

Strings are immutable

String methods create new strings. They do not change the original string in place.

Lists and tuples

Store ordered collections

List

```
items = ["key", "star"]
items.append("mushroom")
items[0] = "map"
```

Read parts

items[0] is the first item. items[-1] is the last. items[1:3] returns a slice.

Common list tools

len(items) value in items items.remove(value)
items.pop() items.sort() items.reverse()

Tuple

```
location = (12, 8)
x, y = location
```

Main difference

Lists are mutable, so their contents can change. Tuples are immutable after creation.

Classes and objects

Future custom types

Class

```
class Player:
    def __init__(self, name):
        self.name = name
        self.lives = 3

    def lose_life(self):
        self.lives -= 1
```

Object

```
hero = Player("Mario")
hero.lose_life()
print(hero.lives)
```

Mental model

A class defines a new type. An object is one instance. Attributes store state; methods define behavior.

self

Inside a method, self refers to the particular object receiving the method call.

Modules and libraries

Future reusable code

Import a module

```
import random
choice = random.choice(items)
```

Import one name

```
from math import sqrt
distance = sqrt(81)
```

Your own module

Put related functions in helpers.py, then use import helpers in another file.

Main guard

```
def main():
    print("Program starts")

if __name__ == "__main__":
    main()
```


Input and conversion

Turn user text into the type you need

Input is always text

```
age_text = input("Age: ")
print(type(age_text))  # str
```

Convert

```
age = int(age_text)
height = float(input("Height: "))
label = str(42)
```

Conversion can fail

int("12") works. int("twelve") raises ValueError because the text is not numeric.

Safe beginner pattern

```
text = input("Whole number: ")
if text.isdigit():
    number = int(text)
else:
    print("Use digits only")
```

Operators and expressions

Build values from other values

Arithmetic

```
total = price * quantity
average = total / count
remainder = number % 2
```

Comparison

== equal != not equal < less > greater <= at most >= at least

Boolean logic

and requires both sides. or requires either side. not reverses the truth value.

Membership and identity

item in items checks membership. value is None checks whether value is the single None object.

Order

Parentheses run first, then arithmetic, comparisons, not, and, and finally or. Use parentheses when clarity matters.

Files and JSON

Future persistent data

Read text

```
with open("notes.txt", "r", encoding="utf-8") as file:
    text = file.read()
```

Write text

```
with open("score.txt", "w", encoding="utf-8") as file:
    file.write(str(score))
```

JSON data

```
import json
with open("player.json", "r") as file:
    player = json.load(file)
```

Why with matters

The with statement closes the file automatically, even if an error interrupts the block.

Exceptions

Future error handling

Expected conversion problem

```
try:
    age = int(input("Age: "))
except ValueError:
    print("Enter a whole number")
```

Common exceptions

SyntaxError invalid code shape NameError unknown name TypeError wrong kind of value IndexError missing position

Catch narrowly

Catch only errors you expect and can handle. Do not use a broad except to hide unexpected failures.

else and finally

An else block runs if no exception occurred. A finally block runs whether an exception occurred or not.

Conditions

Choose which branch runs

Basic pattern

```
if coins >= 10:
    print("1-UP")
elif coins >= 5:
    print("Almost")
else:
    print("Keep going")
```

Only one branch

Python checks conditions from top to bottom and runs the first matching branch.

Truthiness

False, None, zero, and empty strings or collections act false in a condition. Most other values act true.

Common mistake

Use == to compare two values. Use = to assign a value to a name.

For loops and range

Repeat across a collection or number sequence

Loop through values

```
for enemy in ["Boo", "Goomba"]:
    print(enemy)
```

What range produces

range(4) gives 0, 1, 2, 3. The stop value is not included.

Range forms

range(4) # start 0, stop 4
range(2, 5) # 2, 3, 4
range(2, 9, 2) # 2, 4, 6, 8

Accumulator

```
total = 0
for coin in [2, 4, 6]:
    total += coin
```


Dictionaries and sets

Future collection tools

Dictionary

```
player = {"name": "Luigi", "lives": 3}
print(player["name"])
player["lives"] -= 1
```

Safe dictionary lookup

power = player.get("power", "small")

Loop through pairs

```
for key, value in player.items():
    print(key, value)
```

Set

```
tags = {"python", "game"}
tags.add("loops")
```

When to choose each

Use a dictionary for labeled fields. Use a set for unique values and fast membership checks.

Debugging current work

A repeatable process for getting unstuck

1 Read the final error line

Identify the error type and message before changing anything.

2 Inspect the named line

Check spelling, punctuation, indentation, and the types of the values involved.

3 Trace state

Use print or a debugger to observe values before the failure and during each loop iteration.

4 Reduce the problem

Test one expression or function call. Remove unrelated code until the problem is easy to see.

5 Fix and retest

Change one cause at a time, rerun the same test, and add a test that prevents the mistake from returning.

While loops

Repeat while a condition remains true

Basic pattern

```
lives = 3
while lives > 0:
    print(lives)
    lives -= 1
```

Two required ideas

Identify the condition that continues the loop and the update that eventually makes it false.

Infinite loop warning

A while loop continues forever if its condition never becomes false.

Loop controls

break exits the nearest loop. continue skips the rest of the current iteration.

Choose wisely

Use for for a collection or known sequence. Use while when stopping depends on changing state.

Functions

Package a task under a name

Define and call

```
def power(base, bonus):
    total = base + bonus
    return total

score = power(7, 5)
```

Vocabulary

Parameters are names in the definition. Arguments are values supplied by the call.

Return

return ends the function and sends a value to the caller. Save or use that returned value.

Print is different

print displays information. return produces a value that the rest of the program can reuse.

Functions in depth

Understand scope defaults and None

Local scope

```
def double(number):
    result = number * 2
    return result
# result does not exist here
```

Default argument

```
def greet(name, greeting="Hello"):
    return f"{greeting}, {name}"
```

Keyword argument

message = greet(name="Maya", greeting="Hi")

None result

```
def announce(message):
    print(message)

result = announce("Ready")  # None
```

Function habit

Prefer small functions that do one clear job and have names describing that job.